Inverted Minors

Print Page Download PDF

4k Shares

Email Share Post

Inverted minors flip the traditional meaning of single and double minor-suit raises. Playing inverted minors, a single raise of a 1♣/1♦ opening bid is strong and a jump raise is weak. To paraphrase the late Grant Baze, how often do you hear a traditional auction go 1♦ : 2♦ - All Pass? Basically, never. Hence the popularity of inverted raises. You can preempt your opponents with bad hands while bidding more slowly and constructively with good hands.

The Strong Raise (1♣ : 2♣ and 1♦ : 2♦)

The single raise (i.e. 1♣:2♣ and 1♦:2♦) is forcing for one round. The requirements are:

- 10+ points
- At least 4-card support
- No 4-card major

Responder will often be unbalanced, since he can make notrump responses with balanced hands.

♠JT3	Partner	You
♥9	1♣	2♣
♦AQ75		
♣AT643	Your 2♣ bid shows 4+ card support and 10+ points.	

♠976	Partner	You
♥AT9	1♦	2♦
♦KQ875		
♣AK	There is no upper point count limit for a strong raise.	

♠J98	Partner	You
♥Q76	1♣	1NT
♦A65		
♣K853	1NT with 4-3-3-3 shape is more descriptive than an inverted raise.	

The Weak Raise (1♣ : 3♣ or 1♦ : 3♦)

Conversely, the requirements for a weak jump raise (i.e. 1♣:3♣ or 1♦:3♦) are:

- 0-6 points
- At least 5-card support
- No 4-card major

♠J93	Partner	You
♥874	1♣	3♣
♦52		
♣KQ732	3♣ shows 5+ card support and 0-6 points.	

♠975	Partner	You
♥2	1♦	3♦
♦QT987		
♣T754	Ditto.	

Opener's Rebids After 1♣ : 2♣

Rebid	Meaning
2♦	Natural, 4+ cards. Implies imbalanced shape since opener could rebid no-trumps with 2-3-4-4 or 3-2-4-4. Forcing.
2♥/♠	Natural, 3+ cards. Some experts play this as stopper-showing only. Forcing.
2NT	Balanced 12-14 HCP. Not forcing. (Note: If playing weak no-trumps, this would show 15-17 HCP instead.)
3♣	Natural with a 5+ card suit. Not forcing.
3♦	Natural, minimum with a 4+ card suit. Forcing.
3NT	Balanced 18-19 HCP.

Opener's Rebids After 1♦ : 2♦

Rebid	Meaning
2♥/♠	Natural, 3+ cards. Some partnerships treat this as stopper-showing only. Forcing.
2NT	Balanced 12-14 HCP. Not forcing. (Note: If playing weak no-trumps, this would show 15-17 HCP instead.)
3♣	Natural with a 4+ card suit. Probably imbalanced shape. Forcing.
3♦	Natural, minimum with a 5+ card suit. Not forcing.
3NT	Balanced 18-19 HCP.

In Competition

In competition, inverted minors are off for most partnerships. A single raise is weak with 4-card support, and a jump raise is weak with 5+ card support.

If the opponents have doubled for takeout over 1♣/♦, then responder can use the Jordan 2NT convention to show a limit raise or better.

If the opponents have made a natural suit overcall over 1♣/♦, then responder can cuebid to show a limit raise or better.

Constructive Raises

Because inverted minors use 0-6 points for weak raises and 10+ points for strong ones, responder will sometimes be stuck for a bid with 7-9 points. These hands, which would traditionally make a single raise, can no longer do so. The typical approach is to respond 1NT even with unbalanced shape.

♠92	Partner	You
♥87	1♦	1NT
♦AQ75		
♣JT732	Ugh. You must temporize with 1NT because your hand doesn't qualify for anything else.	

Raises by a Passed Hand

If you have already passed, however, you can choose to make a constructive 3♦ raise with 7-9 points and 5+ diamonds. This is because the weak raise is no longer necessary to preempt the opponents, since they have been passing throughout. Note that this treatment requires partnership agreement.

Origins

Inverted minors were originally part of the Kaplan-Sheinwold bidding system that employed 5-card majors and a 12-14 1NT. Although intended to be used with a weak no-trump, inverted minors are compatible with any 1NT range.

See also

- Limit Raises
  A jump raise that shows game-invitational values and 4-card support.
- Jordan 2NT
  An artificial 2NT raise after an opposing takeout double. Promises limit raise strength or better.